General Elphinstone. ‘His manner was most contumacious from the day of his arrival,’ the General wrote later. ‘He never gave me information or advice, but invariably found fault with all that was done.’ This dysfunctional pair of commanders could not agree on a strategy at the outbreak of the uprising in November 1841, but eventually Shelton got his way and at his suggestion the Kabul army marched out of the cantonments on 6 January 1842, only to be annihilated in the snows of the high passes. Shelton was taken hostage, and later tried by court martial, but honourably acquitted. When he was thrown from his horse and died in Dublin in 1844, his men turned out on the parade and gave three cheers to celebrate his demise.

Colin Mackenzie (1806–81): Originally from Perthshire, Mackenzie was renowned as the most handsome young officer in the Indian army. In 1841, as Assistant Political Agent in Peshawar, he went to Kabul where he was caught at the outbreak of the uprising. One of the few British officers to distinguish himself with intelligence and bravery during the fighting, he was eventually taken hostage by Akbar Khan but survived the war to raise and command a Sikh regiment on the Frontier.

George Lawrence (1804–84): George was the elder brother of the more famous Henry and John Lawrence, both of whom later found fame as heroes of the Raj. A bright young Ulsterman, he was fast-promoted by Sir William Macnaghten to be his military secretary. As such, he fought both in the 1839 invasion and in the pursuit of Dost Mohammad, and was present at the latter’s surrender on 4 November 1840. He narrowly escaped death three times: at the outbreak of the uprising in November 1841, at the time of the murder of Macnaghten on 23 December and again during the retreat from Kabul, when he was taken hostage. He survived the war, only to be made prisoner again during the subsequent Sikh war in 1846.

Eldred Pottinger (1811–43): Pottinger was the nephew of the spymaster of Bhuj, and Burnes’s former boss, Sir Henry Pottinger. His presence in disguise in Herat during the Persian siege of 1837–8 was probably more than fortuitous, and provided a stream of much-needed information for the British. In British accounts he is usually credited with steeling the resolve of the Heratis to defend their city, though this is not a version of events